

Whispers before Vanishing

**Culture, Memory, and
Identity of Manchu ethnic
legacy in modern China**



Introduction

Whenever I took out my ID card in front of other kids while commuting to school in Beijing, we would casually glance at one another’s photos since kids all like comparing awkward pictures and pointing out funny faces. But there was one detail that always set mine apart. Beneath my name, next to “ethnicity,” it’s written as: 满 (Manchu). Most of the others had 汉 (Han).

That’s when the questions often would start. “You’re Manchu?” someone would ask.

“Yeah,” I would answer, repeating what my parents had told me: “I’m Manchu.”

Then, the conversation would end. No one really knew what that meant, including me.

We were all taught to celebrate China’s 56 ethnic groups, but inclusiveness often skips the details for each group’s own distinct cultural roots. I carried the label, but I didn’t know the story behind it.

Years later, flying with a friend in the U.S., she saw my ID and asked the same question. I gave the same answer. But this time, she smiled and said, “That’s so cool! You might’ve been a princess in the Qing dynasty.” I laughed, but paused later. I had never connected my identity to history before. *It was the first time I wondered: How could something printed on my ID feel so distant from who I am?*

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Understanding the whole picture: a historical framework

Pre-Qing Conquest

Establishing the Dynasty

Cultural change in Qing

Age of isolationism

Today's Manchu

To better understand the distinct cultural identity of the Manchu people, a historical timeline helps us to trace the transformation and development of the Manchu culture. Although in history classes the term “Manchu” seems to appear from China in Qing Dynasty onward, understanding Manchu culture require us to look much far back. This timeline covers the journey of Manchu people from their early days as fishing and hunting tribes all the way to Manchu people nowadays just like myself.



Pre-Qing Conquest

Jurchen



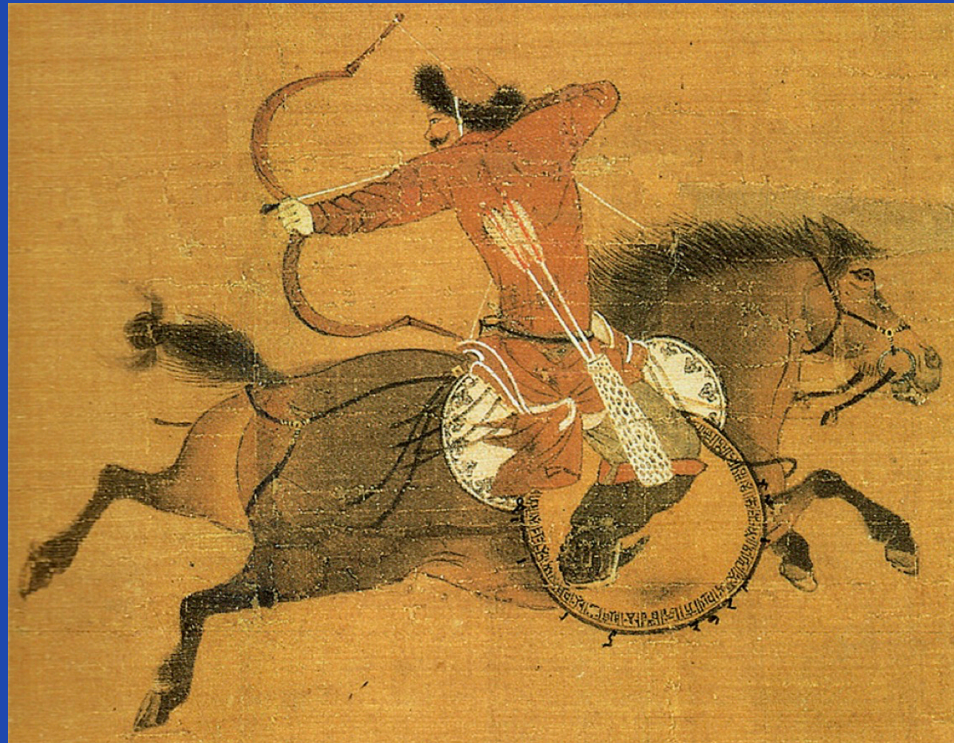
Before the Manchu crossed the Great Wall and established Qing Dynasty, Ming Dynasty established by Han ethnicity group ruled China. During the Ming Dynasty, the Great Wall were built outside of the empire in Beijing to prevent foreign invasions. Before the Manchu people entered the Great Wall, they mainly lived in what is now northeastern China and known as the Jurchens.

They were a fishing and hunting group at this time period, skilled in archery and horseback riding. At the same time, they were also a highly expansionist and nomadic group.

Jurchen developed their own symbols and arts. Their unique way of life not only reflected their relationship with nature, but also their development of a civilization with art and intelligence.



Jurchen Arts



Southern Song Dynasty, Chen Jichong, "Plain Hunting with Deer", album, housed in the National Palace Museum, Taipei



Khan Rest Stop "Rest Stop for the Khan" (5th generation), Hu Rang (10th century) bbs.imobile.com.cn



"The Falcon Painting", Chen Ju-zhong
13thC https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/A_2010-3031-1

Those drawings of Jurchen came from the Jin Dynasty early in the 1100s. The drawings portrays Jurchen having frequent connection with horses, so it is obvious to see their lifestyle with hunting and nomadism. Those drawings also depicts traditional clothing of the Jurchen with long sleeves and belt used to carry bows and arrows.

The sharp lines and powerful style of the artwork effectively convey a strong sense of nomadic identity with freedom and resilience.

Establishing the Dynasty

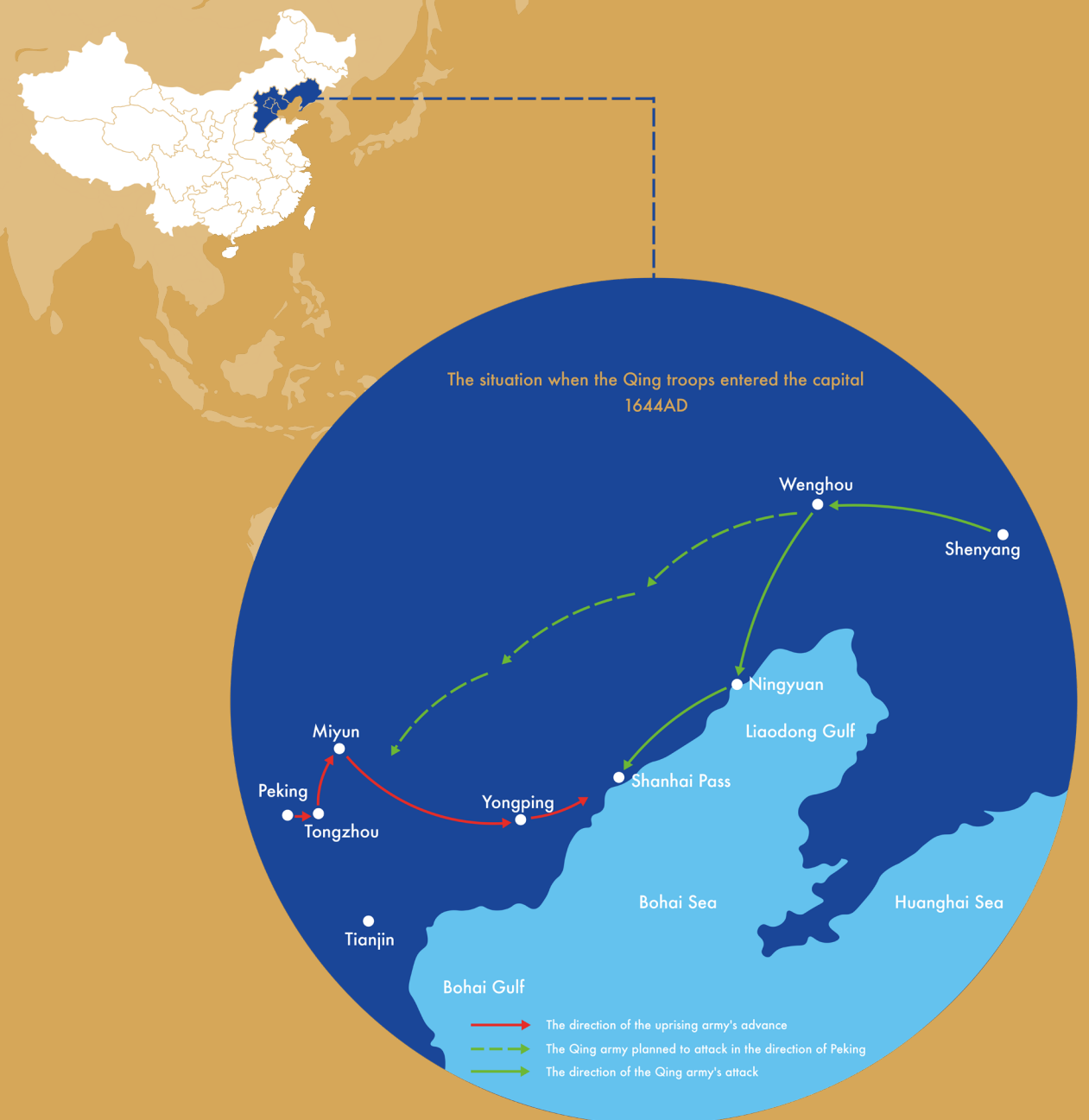
1600s

Nurhaci established the Later Jin regime in 1616, unifying the Jurchen tribes and initiating military expansion. He implemented the “Eight Banners” system that continues in the Qing Dynasty and enhanced the internal organization.

Then in 1636, Nurhaci’s son Hong Taiji changed the empire’s name from “Later Jin” to “Qing”. This marked the formal establishment of the idea of the great Qing dynasty in China. He also adopted the imperial title in China, transitioning from a “khan” from Manchuria to an “emperor”.

In 1644, peasant leader Li Zicheng captured Beijing, leading to the fall of the Ming dynasty.

Afterward, the Qing army formed by the Jurchens (or Manchus) entered the Central Plains. Hong Taiji’s son “The Shunzhi Emperor” ascended the throne, marking the beginning of the Manchu’s rule over China, or the Qing Dynasty. The beginning of the Qing dynasty significantly marked the cultural collision between the Manchu culture and the dominant Han culture from China before.



Cultural change in Qing

The Manchus gained wealth from unifying China and ruled Qing Dynasty. It turned out that half of the elite class in Qing were Manchu. The power and wealth allowed them to put more efforts in creating the unique Qing Dynasty culture and arts.

In the early Qing dynasty, Manchu people were allowed to marry within their own ethnic and social group, but were prohibited from marrying Han Chinese. In an effort to release tensions between the Manchu and Han populations, Qianlong permitted some interethnic marriages. This shift helped bring the two groups closer together, which fostered cultural blending.

One obvious example of this integration was the decline in the use of the Manchu language. As Manchu and Han communities became more connected, Manchu gradually started to speak Chinese in daily life or in official documents. Intermarriage also led to religious blending within families: while the Han commonly practiced



“The Feast at Wan Shu Garden” was painted by Lang Shining and others during the Qianlong period (1736-1795). It is housed in the Palace Museum. The painting depicts the scene where Emperor Qianlong held a banquet in Wan Shu Garden of the Chengde Summer Resort in July of the 17th year of his reign (1754), inviting the Mongolian chieftains to the feast.

Buddhism and Daoism, the Manchu followed traditional shamanism and totemic worship. As families became ethnically mixed, Manchu started to adapt the Han religions.

Another symbolic example of this cultural blending is the famous so-called “Manchu-Han Imperial Feast” (Man Han Quan Xi), a grand meal that blended the culinary traditions of both cultures. It reflects how intermarriage and daily

life brought the Manchu and Han peoples closer under Qing rule.

Through the intermarriage policy and the food tradition, the lifestyles of the two ethnic groups gradually unified. It is difficult to claim which group takes on the dominance to influence the other, but living and building an empire with the Han deeply influence the culture of Manchu through arts, literature and policies.

High-Qing Era

Emperor Kangxi, Emperor Yongzheng and Emperor Qianlong reigned Qing Dynasty from 1661 to 1796, consecutively. Under their reign, Qing reached the heyday of Chinese cultural development. This period was noted as the “High-Qing era”.

During Kangxi’s reign, he invited western missionaries and Chinese craftsman to produce painted enamels. The enamels during Kangxi’s reign emphasizes collaboration and innovation.

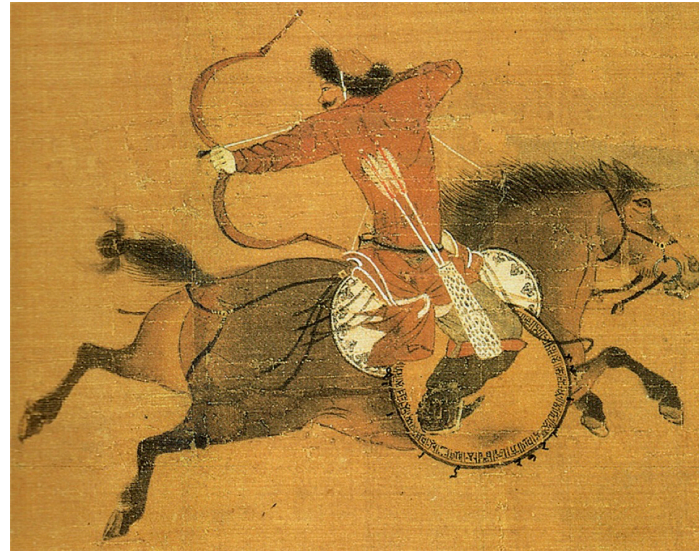
Yongzheng Emperor demonstrated “Imperial Exclusive Style”, which refined painted enamels into a more elegant and exclusive form, intended solely for the imperial court.

Notably, Qianlong emperor was deeply committed to preserving Manchu culture: he even ordered the destruction of thousands of books that portrayed the Manchu people in a negative light. For example, the expansion of the Forbidden City and the Summer Palace demonstrated the architecture achievement during High-Qing Era. As those emperors are all Manchu, they also promoted the traditional Chinese Confucian values as the foundation of their rule.

This era also saw the rise of a strong culture of collecting. The concept of the cabinet of curiosities (百宝格) began to take shape. They are similar to the European tradition of collecting rare and precious objects in ornate display cases.

Arts during the High-Qing era emphasized the social status that the Manchu had in China during the Qing Dynasty as they became noble in the empire. However, as with all things that reach their height, decline was inevitable. As the Manchu rose to noble status, many grew increasingly idle and detached from the realities of governance, indulging in luxury while the empire beneath them slowly began to unravel.

Life scenes of the Qing Dynasty



Southern Song Dynasty, Chen Jichong, “Plain Hunting with Deer”, album, housed in the National Palace Museum, Taipei

Life scenes of the Ming Dynasty



In the Ming Dynasty, “Cypress Garden Appreciation of Antiquities” by Qiu Ying is housed in the Palace Museum.



In the Qing Dynasty, a court painter created this work titled “Screen Painting of ‘Deep Retreat in the Study’ by Yong Prince - Thoughts on Antiquities and the Past”. It is housed in the Palace Museum.

Age of isolationism

During Emperor Qianlong's reign, the Qing Dynasty began to restrict trade with Western countries. In 1757, Qianlong made the closure of all maritime trade ports except for Guangzhou. Later in 1793, British envoy George Macartney visited China hoping to establish equal trade relations, but his request was rejected. At the time, the Qing court believed that China was self-sufficient and had no need for foreign goods.

The government also tightly controlled coastal activities to prevent illegal trade with foreign merchants. These isolationist policies gradually made Chinese society focus on their internal development and cut off from global developments. Most significantly, the Qing Dynasty missed the Industrial Revolution happening in Europe. As a result, China began to fall behind in both military power and economic development compared to the Western world.



After China closed itself off, Britain started the Opium Wars to force trade. China's defeat led to the Treaty of Nanjing, marking the start of semi-colonial control and loss of trade sovereignty.

The Qing's loss in the First Sino-Japanese War (1894–1895) worsened the economy and showed military weakness. In 1898, Emperor Guangxu's Hundred Days' Reform tried to modernize China, but Empress Dowager Cixi ended it after 103 days and reclaimed power.

In 1911, the Qing Dynasty was overthrown by the Xinhai Revolution, ending China's last empire and starting the Republic of China.

The fate of this era was closely tied to the destiny of the Manchu people since they ruled the Qing Dynasty. As the dynasty weakened and fell, the Manchus lost their political dominance and faced challenges to their identity and status within a rapidly changing governance in China.

Yuanmingyuan

The destruction of the Old Summer Palace (Yuanmingyuan) marked a major cultural loss for the Qing Dynasty. Built during the reign of Emperor Kangxi, the palace was an imperial garden that represented the height of Qing architectural and artistic achievement. In October 1860, during the Second Opium War, British and French troops invaded the palace and took majority of priceless Qing era Manchu books and artworks. Soon after, British commander James Bruce ordered the palace to be burned down. The fire raged for three days, causing the glorious cultural center to ruins.

As the value of antique porcelain and artifacts diminished over time, a new underground market emerged known as “ghost markets.” These markets typically operated illegally or semi-legally in hidden areas during the early hours of the morning, where people traded relics and antiques in this secretive environment.



Today's Manchu People

In modern China, the Manchu people are one of the officially recognized 56 ethnic groups. As with other minority groups, their basic rights and cultural heritage are protected and governed under China's ethnic policies.

China's ethnic policy is built on three pillars: Ethnic Equality (民族平等), Ethnic Unity (民族团结), Common Prosperity for All Ethnic Groups (各民族共同繁荣)

The system of "regional ethnic autonomy" grants these ethnic groups the right to manage their own internal rules. Since the founding of the People's Republic, laws including the 1984 Regional Ethnic Autonomy Law, have reinforced the political rights of ethnic minorities. These measures have allowed Manchu communities to retain symbolic recognition and some level of



Regional Ethnic Autonomy Law

self-governance, even as they live in increasingly integrated and multi-ethnic regions.

However, despite this promise of inclusion, the distinct cultural identity of the Manchu has been gradually declined. Historically one of China's most powerful ethnic groups, the Manchu have seen a decline in the use of their native language, traditional customs, and spiritual practices. Urbanization, assimilation, and educational standardization have contributed to this cultural fading. Today, many Manchu people identify more with the broader Han cultural mainstream than with their own ethnic heritage.

What does their ethnic identity mean?

How the culture transform overtime?

Does the Manchu people still walk among us?

How is this identity expressed in modern life?

Late Qing Dynasty through Film

While timeline gives one a thorough knowledge of the historical movements and transformation of Manchu people, one needs details and specific stories to sympathize with the individuals that went through the transformation. A civilization is built by several individuals, and therefore understanding the individual suffering reflects how the Manchu culture faded in our modern society. Film and media that portrays fictional stories adapted by real individual suffering under the historical context could vividly bring us imagery and new perspectives.

Released in 1992 and directed by Chen Kaige, *Farewell My Concubine* is set during the time period of the transition between Late Qing Dynasty to the founding of Republican China. The film won the Palme d'Or at the 46th Cannes

Film Festival, becoming one of the most internationally acclaimed works in Chinese cinema.

The plot is established around the two male protagonists that begin training in Peking Opera from a young age. The film was set in the period from the later Qing to the China's Cultural revolution in Mao Era. Against the backdrop of great historical change, their attitudes toward love, society, and their passion gradually evolve.

Since the main plot is set during the Republic of China period and after the founding of the People's Republic of China, we can clearly see the segments that reflect the process of the disappearance of the Manchu people.

霸王别姬 FAREWELL MY CONCUBINE





His first appearance is during the childhood performance of the Peking Opera Farewell My Concubine by the two protagonists. He has a deep love for Peking opera, and possesses a refined appreciation for the art form. He also holds the cultural and financial status to support and cultivate the arts as a Manchu in Qing.



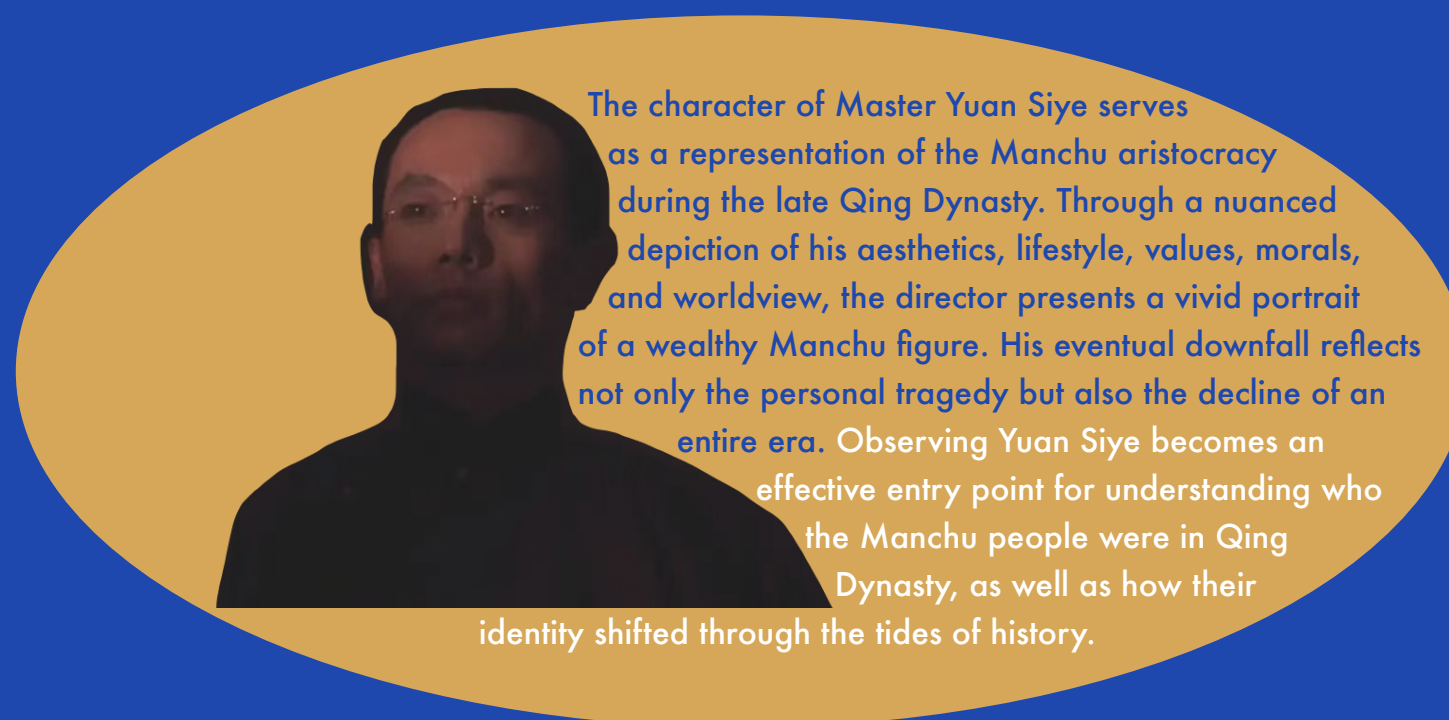
He is a figure others once looked up to. Before he arrive to the back stage after the opera ends, everyone eagerly anticipates his arrival. Gaining his approval symbolized having achieved a significant level of mastery in opera.



When he first watches the two protagonist, Duan Xiaolou and Dieyi perform, he comments backstage that Xiaolou took a wrong step. To Xiaolou, such a detail means little because performing is simply his job. In contrast, Yuan Siye's noble background allows him to appreciate the most delicate and refined aspects of the art.

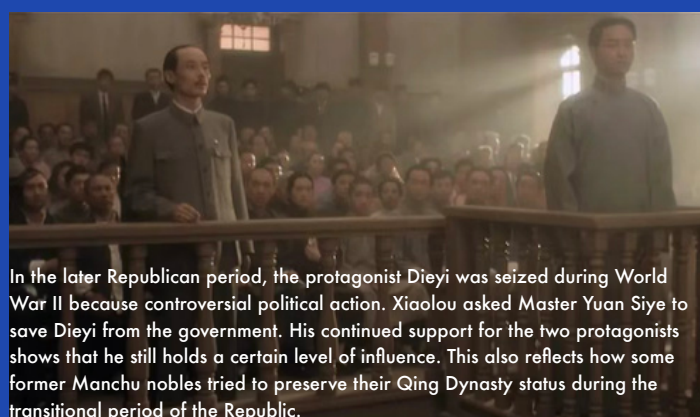


Later in the story when the two protagonists' grow up, they're not partner in the Opera anymore. However, they viewed Yuan Siye as always a figure to admire and respect, which could be seen in their conversations. This emphasized Yuan Siye's status is not only in arts and opera, but also socially and politically.



During the Qing Dynasty, it was common for nobles to collect rare and valuable objects as a way to display their taste and wealth. The sword was part of Yuan Siye's personal collection.

When Yuan Siye gives the protagonist Dieyi the sword as a gift, Dieyi sees it as a great honor. This moment once again highlights Yuan Siye's high status during the Qing Dynasty. It also reflects how Manchu nobles, like Yuan Siye, often collected valuable items to display their wealth.



In this scene, Yuan changes from wearing a traditional robe from Qing Dynasty, as seen in earlier scenes, to a Zhongshan suit (a style associated with modern political and social reform in 20th-century China). This change in costume highlights not only the passing of time and the shift in historical context, but also suggests a deeper transformation in Yuan Siye's personal identity and values.



The founding of the People's Republic of China and the beginning of the Cultural Revolution completely overturned the old social order. During the Cultural Revolution, farmers and workers were seen as honorable, while former aristocrats were condemned as inherently guilty. Those who had once enjoyed privileged lives based on status rather than labor were now accused and overthrown. Yuan Siye was one of them. Yuan Siye was branded a "reactionary opera tyrant" and sentenced to execution. In this moment, he showed no fear. With a calm face, he stepped firmly and resolutely to his death.



During this time, former nobles like Yuan Siye were labeled as counterrevolutionaries. Ironically, when Yuan Siye was sentenced to death, many were shocked because they couldn't imagine such a once glorious figure meeting such a tragic end.

The transformation of Yuan Siye's identity and status serves as a lens through which we can understand the broader historical shifts experienced by the Manchu people. A once glorious ethnic group and its culture were, within a short span of time, reduced to public criticism.

In portraying Yuan Siye, the film makes extensive use of props and settings to reflect the aesthetics, lifestyle, and values of the Manchu aristocracy. These visual elements such as personal ornaments, decorative patterns, and daily customs vividly depict their refined style and way of life. However, these cultural symbols are not static; they have continuously evolved throughout history.

Transformation of Visual Elements

What caused these changes? What forces drove this transformation? These are the questions I aim to explore in the next section, where I will reveal that cultural fusion played a key role in shaping the aesthetic evolution of the Manchu people. The visual elements I choose shows impressive transform in their functions and appearance.

Symbolism of Wen Wan Thumb ring

Wen Wan refers to culturally rich, refined objects that are appreciated for their design, history, and the tactile pleasure of handling them. "Wen" in Chinese means scholarly and culturally elegance, while "Wan" in Chinese means "to play with".



Qing Dynasty (Emperor Qianlong period), carved purple sandalwood box with a coiled dragon design.

A popular saying in Qing captures the explanation and example of Wen Wan: “A prince’s three treasures: a thumb ring, walnuts, and a caged bird.” This vividly reflects the refined tastes and leisurely culture of the aristocracy.

Dynasty, the thumb ring (扳指) that shows prestige and social status in the dynasty actually existed decades before in the hunting and nomadic society. Originally, it was designed to protect hunters and soldier’s thumb when drawing the bowstring. It was also used to generate power to aid in the smooth release of the arrow, as most thumb rings are smoothed and polished.

As the Manchu people gained control of Qing, martial skills were still deeply embedded in their identity. Emperors like Kangxi, Yongzheng, and Qianlong repeatedly emphasized the importance of remembering their ancestors’ warrior spirit. As a result, wearing a thumb ring became a common custom among Qing dynasty officials, symbolizing not only military readiness but also a connection to Manchu heritage.

Apparently, the noble class in Qing didn’t need to hunt anymore. During this time, the thumb ring became fashionable for officials and nobles to carry.



Symbolism of Motifs and Patterns

Before the Manchus entered the Central Plains, their printed patterns were closely tied to Shamanistic beliefs. One important pattern was the Tree of Life, often portrays as a simple and unadorned willow tree reflecting the natural spirituality of early Jurchen culture. In the Jurchen culture, portraying natural plants was a way to protect against the evil spirit.

After settling in Qing Dynasty, Manchu textile patterns became more decorative under Han Chinese influence. Designs such as floral patterns become more popular.

The Han concept of “Four Gentlemen” deeply influence the Manchu textile pattern—plum blossom, orchid, bamboo, and chrysanthemum. They each represent noble moral virtues in traditional Han culture:

Plum: resilience, blooming in winter
Orchid: honor and literature
Bamboo: humble
Chrysanthemum: gentle

This evolution in plant pattern and motifs reflects more than just aesthetic change. It reveals the cultural fusion between Manchu and Han traditions, blending spiritual symbolism with Han Confucian values.



Manchu Life Tree

In the early motifs in the Jurchen culture, "Tree of life" (willow tree) demonstrates hope and resilience. Therefore, from an aesthetic aspect, these motifs feel abstract, textured, and forceful.



Blue and white porcelain plate with pine, bamboo and plum pattern, Ming Dynasty, Xuande period

In the Ming Dynasty (1368-1644), an era that the Han Chinese still rules the Chinese dynasty, many poets and literati influenced their motifs. Therefore, the patterns of bamboos are slender and elegant.



'Lost in Thought while Viewing Antiques', from the Yongzheng shier meiren tu

Looking at the bamboo motifs during the Qing Dynasty, we can clearly see the impact of cultural integration. In the third image, the screen behind the woman is painted with bamboo, which appears noticeably thicker and more robust than the ones from the previous dynasty (Ming Dynasty). This visual shift reflects the aesthetic influence of the Jurchen people, a nomadic and hunting-based culture that preceded the Manchus.

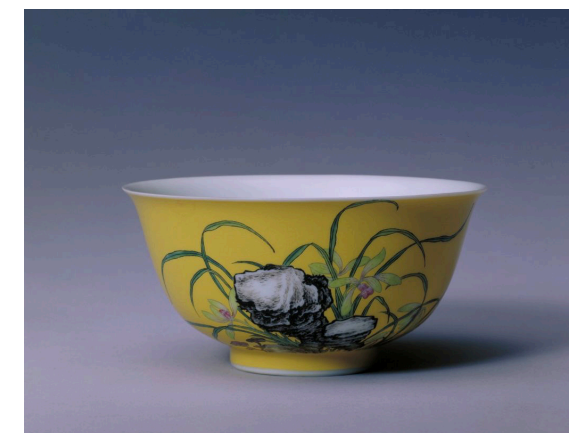


The paper-cut patterns of the "Mother Willow Tree" of the Manchu ethnic group

This group of images shows a similar story. In the early Jurchen motifs, grass is depicted in an extremely simplified way. In contrast, in the Ming dynasty, craftsmen portrayed orchids in a more realistic way with the complicated layering of leaves. In the final imperial artifact shown at the bottom, not only is the realism from the Ming dynasty preserved, but a small rock is also placed beside the plant, creating a miniature landscape. These aesthetic transitions reflect more than just stylistic choices. Rather, they were shaped by shifts in lifestyle, historical context, and the cultural exchange between the two ethnic groups.



Red lacquer round box with plum and orchid patterns, Yongle period of the Ming Dynasty



Pale yellow enamel-painted orchid-patterned stone-patterned bowl, Qianlong Yongzheng period

Customs for Bird-Keeping

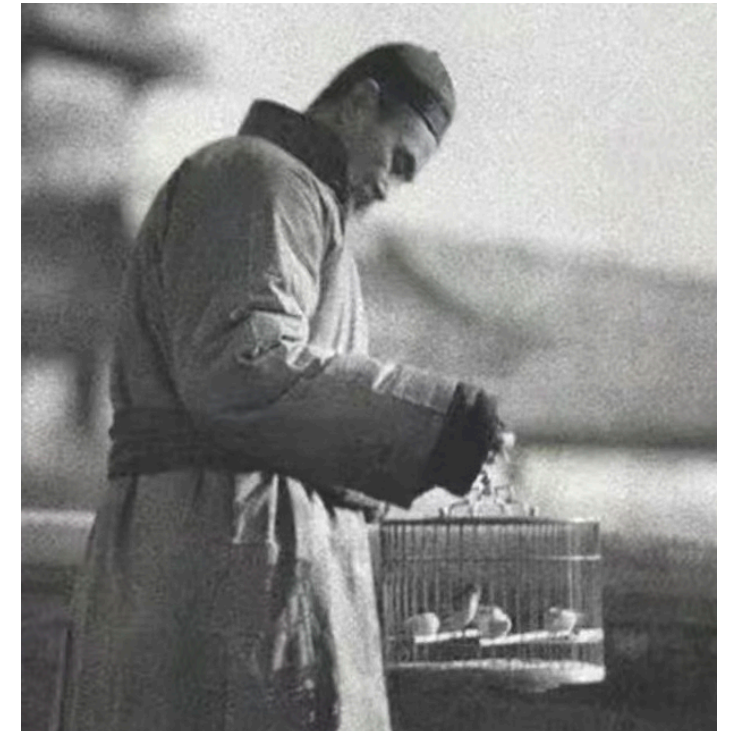
In the era that Manchu was still nomadic tribe, parrots were used to assist nomadic life by playing a role of companions and aids in communication and alertness. Later, bird-keeping became a popular hobby among Qing dynasty's Eight Banners families. Carrying a birdcage was once a negative description for people who did not work. Over time, it spread to hard-working people, offering them moments of rest and comfort.

It is common to see a birdcage hanging on a small tree near street vendors like shoemakers, tofu sellers, or horseshoe makers. The bird serves as their companion. Most bird keepers tend to be older, typically between 50 and 80 years old, mostly retired workers, with fewer active workers involved.

Beijing bird enthusiasts keep various species, generally categorized into large birds and small birds. Large birds mainly include thrush-

es and larks, while small birds are mostly red and yellow finches. The primary appeal is the birds' songs, but their appearance also matters. Thrushes are prized for their clear white eye-rings, and larks for their large heads and short beaks. Bird keepers share detailed aesthetic standards, widely recognized within the community, which creates significant status differences among the birds.

Similarly, pigeon or cricket keeping also requires leisure time and a refined sense of aesthetics. Through how bird-keeping evolved, we see the value that the Manchu people hold behind it: meticulous, playful and refined. The purpose of bird-keeping evolve from a tool for hunting, to a leisure activity, and finally evolving to a cultural symbolism of the fading dynasty. From this transformation, we could see how Manchu's identity gradually shift from a nomadic tribe to the noble ruling a dynasty.



Today, the identity of the Manchu people has become scattered and subtle. For people like me, it's difficult to define this "identity," and even harder to find it within myself.

Sometimes, others may question whether this identity has already faded into the vast sea of homogenized humanity in China. However, by analyzing how identity changes over time, we can see that this "fading" is actually a kind of transformation that is not necessarily a negative one. Rather than disappearing, the identity has taken on a more hidden, form.

Take bird keeping as an example, it is no longer commonly practiced among the community today. However, I've tried to uncover the underlying qualities that still persist, such as meticulousness and a deep sense of care. These qualities, though detached from their original form, continue within the Manchu people.

To find what could represent this "identity" and what are the values that persist, I interviewed two people in my life that all have "Manchu" written on their ID card like me.



Today's fragmented memories on Manchu

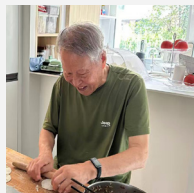
Interview with grandfather

I have lived with my grandfather since I was born. He is humorous, knowledgeable, and caring, and we have chatted about many things together – his memories from college, his story with my grandma, or his childhood – but I haven't seen him mention anything about his Manchu identity throughout our conversations.

Before I started this interview about his Manchu identity, I recount some of his hobbies and qualities that I could expand on in my interview, like his obsession in collecting photos, drawing, and bird keeping. However, I need to be careful in making distinctions. Many of my grandfather's hobbies do share similarities with Qing-era traits, but they may not necessarily stem from his Manchu identity. Instead, many of these habits are simply part of who he is as an elderly intellectual in China. Therefore, it's important for me to recognize these differences during the interview.

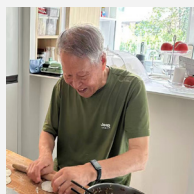


Do you identify yourself as Manchu? How would you define what it means to be Manchu?



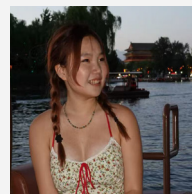
I think in today's society, there's really no visible difference between Manchu people and Han people. Saying I'm Manchu is really just a label that I tell others, but it doesn't come with any real difference in daily life. Because my mother is already Han ethnicity, on our family's official household record, my ethnicity was already listed as Han Chinese by my generation.

What do you think "Manchu" means culturally?

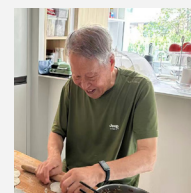


Manchu culture can be seen in clothing and daily customs in the past. But to be honest, I feel I no longer have much connection with it now. However, being with my grandfather, who lived during the Qing Dynasty and didn't pass away until I was in my second year of college, reminded me Manchu culture. He was part of the Zhengbaiqi banner (one of the Eight Banners, the military and administrative divisions of the Manchu people during the Qing Dynasty).

You could see the Manchu lifestyle in him: he lived in a siheyuan (traditional Beijing courtyard), raised pigeons and rabbits, grew flowers, and took his birdcage out on walks. He had a slow paced and relaxed life. Even in recent years, I'd still see a few old men in the nearby park walking their birds. These kinds of habits might seem like ordinary retiree hobbies now, but I think they reflect a lifestyle that's been quietly passed down.

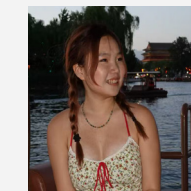


Were there any traditions or customs in your childhood that might relate to Manchu culture?



One thing that comes to mind is how we addressed family members. I called my aunt "guba" (meaning "aunt-dad" literally), which always confused my Han friends since they didn't understand why a woman would be called "dad." And uncles were often called by terms like "father" too. I'm not sure if this is strictly a Manchu thing, but it felt unique to our family.

Also, I grew up in a three-generation household with grandparents, parents, and children all living together. Respecting the elderly and taking care of the young was deeply rooted in how we lived. That kind of family structure feels like part of the cultural inheritance too.

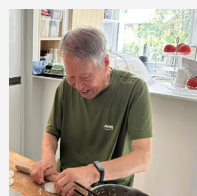
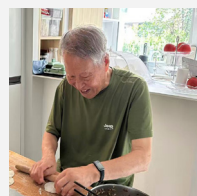


What do you remember about the house you lived in as a child?



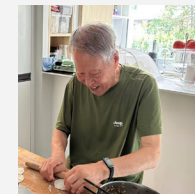
Our old home was a traditional siheyuan courtyard in the heart of Beijing, left to us by my grandfather's grandfather. It used to be quite elegant with the decorative patterns on the roof. The layout was also very traditional: a narrow heated bed platform in the main hall, with a small table in the middle and long side tables on either side. Elders would sit cross-legged on the bed, leaning against big cushions. We'll see that setup in many films about the Qing Dynasty.

There was a couplet on the door that said: "Passing down kindness through generations, continuing the legacy with poetry and books." It taught us to be honest people and value education, a kind of family virtue that I believe many Manchu families once emphasized.

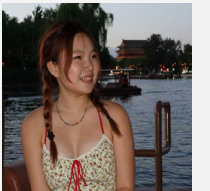
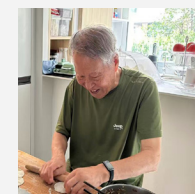
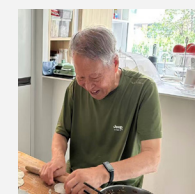


In these two questions, my grandfather mentioned the family virtue of kindness and respecting multiple times talking about their family tradition. However, those virtues are emphasized more in the Confucianism philosophy, which is indeed unique in China but not a symbol of Manchu culture.

Are there any antiques that have been passed down in your family?



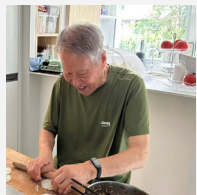
Yes, there's a cricket jar that has been passed down in the family that we still have it at home. There's also a square kang table (small tables that was used on the bed) made from very fine wood. Back then, our home was very particular about furniture: there had to be a central table, grand armchairs, and a pair of matching tea tables, each made with different types of wood, refined and symmetrical. I think that sense of meticulousness might be part of what was passed down from Manchu traditions.





Just like bird-keeping, cricket keeping also became a popular leisure activity in Qing dynasty. When my grandfather first talked about this cricket jar, I thought the jar would be small, light and simple made by wood or plastic. That said, the actual jar was made by heavy stone. There are many small parts inside, and there are patterns on all parts. The jar shows how much thoughts that the Manchu people put on these leisure activities.

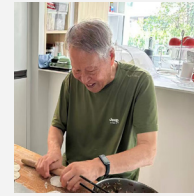
When do you think Manchu culture started to “disappear”? What’s the difference between assimilation and disappearance?



Manchu culture began to blend with Han culture as early as the Qing Dynasty’s entry into China. Language is a clear example. In the beginning, Manchu script was still used, but gradually, Han characters became dominant. In the later Qing, Han cultural influence had grown stronger, and even the Manchu emperors were taught by Han tutors and became highly proficient in Han Chinese culture.

So in a way, Manchu culture wasn’t so much erased as it was absorbed. It didn’t vanish. The culture just merged in, and many things became habits that are no longer recognized as “Manchu.” They’re still there, just hidden inside of us.

These days, anyone who can still read Manchu language is a rare genius. That’s because they’re the only ones who can decipher Qing Dynasty archives and historical documents.



After speaking with my grandfather, I turned to my grandmother, who doesn’t have Manchu heritage, for her memories. She recalled how “Those Eight Banner kids used to be so proud,” and “your grandfather wore suits as a boy to keep up that image.” But by the time he was born, no one really claimed that identity openly anymore. She only learned he was Manchu after they got married, during the Cultural Revolution, when people had to trace their family backgrounds. “After decades”, she laughed, “everyone suddenly remembered they were a minority, because it meant extra college points for those ethnic groups.”

She also mentioned how common Manchu roots were in Beijing. “In my university dorm, half of us were Manchu,” she said. One girl even came from a royal lineage, and her father practiced gongbi painting, a detailed style passed down in their family. But aside from that, their daily lives looked no different from anyone else’s”.

Both my grandfather and grandmother’s perspectives reveal how historical transitions shape personal identity. When they were young, the Qing Dynasty wasn’t yet a distant past, so echoes of Eight Banner culture were still visible in everyday life, from wearing suits as a symbol of pride to raising birds and crickets with dedication. These weren’t performances of heritage; they were simply how they lived. Even today, when people speak of “Beijing locals” in China, images of bird cages, crickets, and Eight Banner descendants still appears. In this way, Manchu traditions didn’t just fade, they also helped shape the cultural texture and imagination of the city Beijing itself.

Interview with Ms. Sirge

Ms. Sirge is an inheritor of the Manchu zheng (a traditional instrument) tradition. Ms. Sirge was raised in Changchun (in Liaoning Province), a city in the Northeastern part of China. Now, she is active in organizations that spread awareness of all Chinese ethnic minorities. At the same time, she hosts musical performances with Manchu Zheng and organizes people to celebrate Manchu festivals together.

I reached out to Ms. Sirge on the internet and scheduled an interview with her. Talking to Ms. Sirge, my knowledge of Manchu culture seems to be a tip of the iceberg compared to hers.



How do you view your Manchu identity now and before?



The concept of “I am a Manchu people” came inside of me since I was young. My grandmother would give me hand-made Manchu style clothing, like a blue dress with meticulous decorations. I have had a certain understanding of my ethnic identity. Unlike some children who have no definite concept of this, I know my heritage are quite different from others.

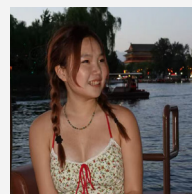
In 2013, I began studying the Manchu language and explored performing Manchu folk songs with the gu-zheng (A traditional instrument from the Han Chinese). After receiving feedback that the instrument I used wasn’t authentically Manchu, I realized how little was known about traditional Manchu instruments. This led to a deep journey of discovery visiting folk musicians, cultural heritage bearers, and national-level masters to research Manchu music. Eventually, I became a student of Professor Huang, a leading scholar at the Palace Museum and artistic director of the Temple of Heaven. Under his guidance, I helped revive and adapt unique Manchu instruments and music. Through performances, I’ve been able to share the distinctive spirit of Manchu music with wider audiences.

In 2016, there was a Manchu election competition for entertainment held in Chengde, China. I won the title of the prettiest “Manchu princess” because I could play and sing in Manchu. It was for this that I gained some attention from the city’s public. Later, becoming an “ambassador”, I also felt a sense of responsibility and commitment. I am very fond of history and have learned how the Qing Dynasty ruled China. As a Manchu, I feel very proud and honored to have unified China in this way as a minority.



The qipao is a type of women's clothing that was invented in modern times. It is a fusion of the traditional long robe worn by Manchu women during the Qing Dynasty and Western-style dress.

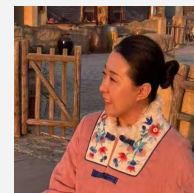
In your experience, how are Manchu people's daily lives nowadays different from those of Han Chinese today?



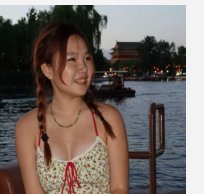
I grew up in an urban city, so I suppose I'm not naturally used to rural life. But I've always had a deep love for nomadic lifestyle, like hiking and horseback riding. Even though I've settled in places like Beijing or Changchun, both major cities in northern China, I still feel a strong connection to mountains and rivers far away. I think it might be a reflection of some hunting-and-fishing roots from the Jurchen era.

From the Manchu people I've met, along with Mongolians and Xibe people, I can always see generosity that really stands out when they interact with others or deal with things. It's quite different from the subtleties you often find in southern China. Even though we no longer live in forests or on the grasslands, I feel like those personality traits are still somehow stayed in our blood. This traits really stands out especially during collective moments.

Do you think that the change in Manchu culture during Qing Dynasty was a form of cultural integration, or was it the loss of part of Manchu identity? What's the difference between integration and fade?



To me, it wasn't just the Manchu people who changed during the Qing Dynasty. Because we're not Qing people ourselves, so it's hard to explain the process and define "change". In fact, when the Manchus entered China, you could also argue that the Han were assimilated by them to a great extent. One of the examples of that is the Queue Order (剃发令), which required Han people to shave the front of their heads and wear long braids. The Qing rulers saw this as a sign of loyalty to Manchu authority and culture. Isn't that a form of assimilation by the Han?





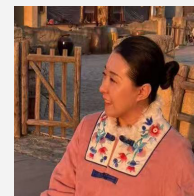
So I believe that cultural integration is mutual, not just fading of Manchu culture. Today, many mainstream and social media outlets talk about how minority cultures are being assimilated, but if you think about it, isn't modern China itself being westernized as well? In that sense, I think this kind of cultural change is completely normal. Ultimately, how you interpret it really depends on different perspectives.

Were there any family traditions or customs that your family especially valued?



Back in the 1980s, when I was a child, I still had some relatives living in the countryside. During Chinese New Year, we'd do things like slaughtering pigs for the festivities, which is something that nearly impossible to see these days. Now everything feels more formalized, more symbolic, and that original "feeling" of the holiday seems to be fading away.

As I got older, I became involved in promoting Manchu music and related cultural work. Over the past decade or so, I've started celebrating festivals that are specific to the Manchu and other ethnic minorities—like Banjin Festival (颁金节) for the Manchu, and the Westward Migration Festival (西迁节) for the Xibe. I'm often invited to perform or participate in these events.



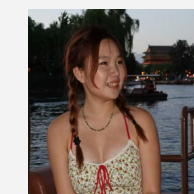
"Banjin Festival" is a traditional Manchu festival. "Banjin" it is a transliteration of the Manchu phrase "banjin inenggi", where banjin means "birth" and inenggi means "day". Therefore, Banjin Festival literally means "Birthday of the Manchu people".

In your opinion, how can we better preserve and promote these kinds of traditional Manchu arts and festivals today?



I think the most important thing is to adapt with the times. A great example is the recent video game Black Myth: Wukong. It went popular even internationally. That's a powerful case of spreading a cultural mythology. We don't necessarily need to keep everything "authentic" to the point of being outdated. What's more important is to make it relevant to contemporary life, so it feels familiar and accessible, not distant or exotic.

I've also seen Manchu artists creating comics based on traditional Manchu folklore and history. For example, there is a video game called Nishan Shaman (尼山萨满). I think that's a fascinating approach. If we can use ways that young people enjoy, like games or animations, then these cultural traditions can be easier to promote and preserve.



Reflection: varied definitions of Manchu

When I ask Ms. Seirge to identify some of her quality that might be a heritage from the Manchu qualities, Ms. Seirge immediately linked “Manchu identity” to its nomadic qualities in the Jurchen era, such as the connection with nature. On the other hand, my grandparents tried to find connection with my grandfather and the Qing Dynasty Manchu, saying hobbies like bird-keeping, or a slow-paced life.

Can we summarize the hidden qualities of Manchu using one word? This ethnicity evolved in every stage in history and adapted in new lifestyles, so people’s perception on “Manchu Quality” nowadays in China varies, and the word “Manchu” brings them back to different time period.

To see what people generally interpreted as

“Manchu quality” could help us fully understand the hidden parts of Manchu that continues to preserve nowadays. The survey asks 140 people from northern China (more familiar with Manchu history) about what is the first word that comes in their mind thinking of Manchu.

Together, these words show that “Manchu identity” is multi-layered and shaped by different historical time period, just like the different definition that my grandfather and Ms. Sirge. The amount of respondents who linked Manchu identity with its Qing Dynasty quality is almost equal to the amount of people who connect Manchu with its nomadic heritage. The word “Manchu” no longer refers only to an ethnic label, but becomes a collective image of varied experiences.



Different cultural integrations on global scope



Ms. Sirge's response to the difference between integration and fading is unique: she states that Han culture was also affected by Manchu culture. However, because Han is the mainstream group in China nowadays, relatively minority ethnic groups like the Manchu became "ethnic minorities".

When does cultural integration become mutual, and when does it represent erasure?

tinct dynamic, either cultural integration or cultural erasure. For example, the Indigenous American culture significantly faded after col-

onization and forced assimilation. In contrast, the Ottoman Empire managed to give different ethnic groups under one system, so the Islamic culture remained dominant but absorbed elements from Arab, Greek, and Persian traditions.

For Manchu people, the line between fading and integration becomes more complex, because many Manchu customs became so embedded in Han life that people no longer recognize them as "Manchu." However, the fact that Manchu culture still influenced Chinese society, noticed or not, helps them to continue their legacy.

Portrait, ca. 1890s, from the Carlisle Indian Industrial School, titled "Educating the Indian Race. Graduating Class of Carlisle, PA." (Photo source: Wikimedia Commons)



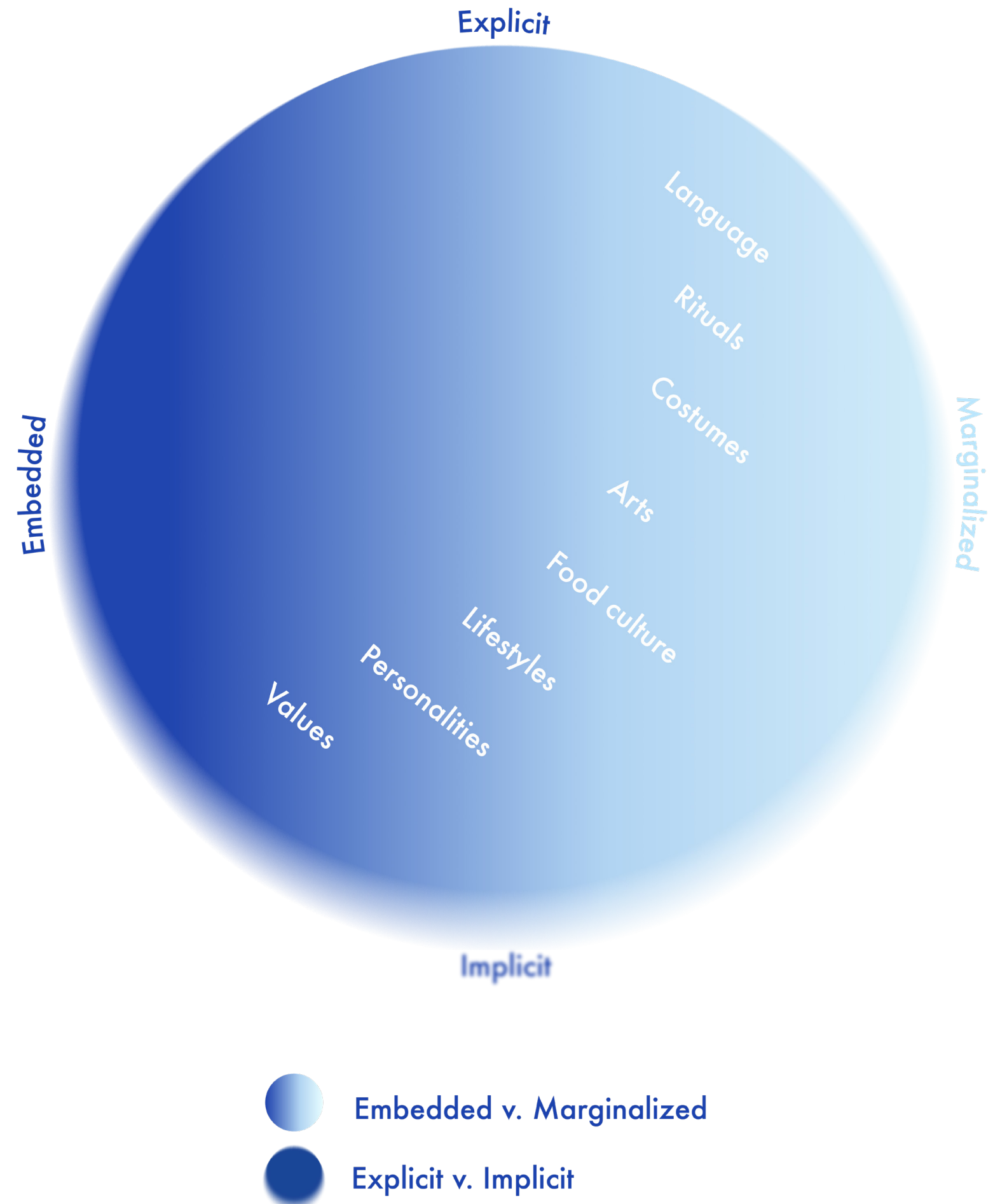
Ottoman Empire

Conclusion on explicit and implicit cultures

The illustration expresses an abstract framework of the current state of Manchu cultural element persisting in China according to my previous interviews and researches. From left to right, the transition of blue shades moves from dark blue to light blue, showing the elements from “embedded” to “marginalized”. This represents the visibility of those Manchu elements in the daily lives now. From up to down, the background goes from focus to blurred, showing the most “explicit” elements to the most “implicit” ones. This explains whether those elements are tangibly expressed (like an actual object) or conceptual and unspoken.

Interestingly, the shades of the background and the words show a paradox: elements like language, rituals, and costumes are tangible and marked people’s identities, but are now rarely seen in everyday life. Practices like food, art, and lifestyle lie in the middle, some preserved to mainstream regional culture. Meanwhile embedded traits like personality or values are the hardest to recognize as “Manchu”, but they still shape people’s behaviors, decisions, and personal beliefs in subtle ways.

This conceptual graph reveals a phenomenon: what is most visible may be lost, while what is



invisible may preserve. The more abstract and invisible a cultural element is the more likely it is to be preserved unconsciously. These traits often continue to shape the way people behaves, talks, and response, and they unconsciously impacted people around them and the next generation. People sometimes no longer identify those elements as “Manchu.” The implicit culture (the unspoken norms) might be interpreted as universal common sense rather than cultural heritage. At this point, it becomes difficult to clearly define whether a certain trait belongs to Manchu culture or is just a part of broader regional norms.

On the other hand, concrete and explicit cultural elements require a long and intentional process of preservation. This kind of conscious cultural preservation demands time, effort, and a strong sense of identity and ambition.

This phenomenon not only existed in the crisis of Manchu culture or Chinese ethnic minority groups, but becomes a worldwide debate. In our world now, the societies became a “global village” according to Marshall McLuhan’s theory, reflecting that communication technologies is shrinking the world into a village. The cohesion of different ideas, languages, fashions might bring up cultural homogenization – individual

cultures might sacrifice themselves to globalized, westernized norms. People in different countries might watch the same Netflix show or wear the same brand, but the way they think and interpret the world are still deeply affected by their cultural background.

However, when concrete boundaries of identities are broken, it is hard for future generations to identify their roots. Intangible cultural elements risk eventually being absorbed into broader cultural norms. Thus, cultural preservation need to go beyond museums or performances. It should involve deep self-reflection. If we can trace how implicit culture shapes our

instincts, judgments, and behaviors, we do more than preserve identity. As a student who carries Manchu heritage, grew up in a Chinese family, and has lived across multiple American states, I’ve come to see cultural identity not only as an obvious presentation, but also invisible influences. When I notice how certain values persist in me and my family despite years of migration, or how my own instincts sometimes reflect heritages I didn’t consciously learn, I realize that understanding implicit culture is deeply personal to every one of us. To understand the reason behind how we think is the first step to decide which part of ourselves we truly want to keep.

Solving identity crisis

Solving an identity crisis begins with one active choice. For Ms. Sirge, this choice start with learning Manchu music and language. In the process of learning the skill, she could also approach her root as a Manchu more, and thus broaden her worldview.

“Culture” is a verb, and it is continually shaped through learning, storytelling, and participation. The more cultures we came into contact with, the more our perspective could be widened. Gradually, we can better understand where we’re from and who we are.

Ultimately, I advocate for young people facing cultural disconnection and question their cultural identity to start with one simple step: learning a piece of historical story, a word, or a skill from their heritage. Like Ms. Sirge, learning a Manchu song or language not only helped her to maintain the explicit cultural form, but also embedded herself into the values, lifestyles, and perspectives of Manchu people. Rather than making culture staying in history textbooks, in this way, cultural identities would become dynamic and evolving through generations.